

spokesperson. Former editor of *Panchjanya*, the RSS mouthpiece, Tarun Vijay, and Jawaharlal Nehru University scholar from Andhra Pradesh Nirmala Sitharaman were also included in the new team of BJP spokespersons.

Though some party leaders said that Hussain was not happy since he was expecting a general secretary's post, he himself denied it. "I have no complaints. My party does not believe in appeasement on grounds of religion or caste," he said, putting up a brave face. The only leaders with some kind of a national profile who made it to Gadkari's team include Vasundhara Raje and Ananth Kumar, both general secretaries. Varun Gandhi, the party's Hindutva poster-boy, was the youngest to make it to the list at 30. Appointed secretary, Varun was earlier believed to have been offered a top post in the Uttar Pradesh state unit, which he declined. He was also considered for taking charge of the party's youth wing. However, with him in the organisation now, young MP Anurag Thakur, son of Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Prem Kumar Dhumal, is tipped to take over as the president of Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha.

As the BJP constitution made it compulsory to include 25 per cent "new faces" who were not part of the outgoing executive, most of them were included as secretaries. The new young faces like Varun Gandhi, Navjot Singh Sidhu, Smriti Irani of *saas-bahu* serials, Saroj Pandey and Vani Tripathi were expected to counter the Congress youth brigade led by Rahul Gandhi. Those who were looking for drastic changes were disappointed. "There seems to be no logic in cobbling up the team. While a large number of leaders with no mass base or any intellectual input to give have been inducted into the national executive as office bearers, others like Yashwant Sinha and Arun Shourie have been given a miss. It just shows that those who questioned the party line and dissented will find

it difficult to be accommodated," said a party leader.

This goes against what Gadkari had said soon after taking over that he would like to reach out to the dissenters to make the party stronger. "The nuclear deal is back in news with the Government deferring the bill. Sinha and Shourie are the only two people in the BJP who understand the nuances of the deal and could provide valuable inputs at the party forum. Jaswant Singh is another person who understands the subject. With him being out of the party, Gadkari should have included, at least, Sinha in the executive," said the leader.

Gadkari has also failed to introduce domain expertise in his team. Even as terrorism and internal security remain major issues before the country, there is not even a single person in the core team who can claim to be an expert in the area. For that matter, there is nobody who can talk about climate change or hold forth on finance and economy.

However, Gadkari was obviously bogged down by other considerations of regional representation, ensuring the presence of Dalits and SC/STs, in addition to 33 per cent women. While members like Najma Heptullah and Hema Malini, both from the Rajya Sabha, made it to the top team only because the BJP had promised one-third representation to women. Thawarchand Gehlot continued to be the general secretary because of Dalit representation. Arjun Munda made it to the list as general secretary because of his ST status and Ramnath Kovind became a spokesperson as a

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THE Usual Suspect

Gadkari loses the plot in his

WOMEN POWER

HEMA MALINI Vice-president
KARUNA SHUKLA Vice-president
SMRITI IRANI Secretary
VANI TRIPATHI Secretary
SHAINA NC Member
KIRRON KHER Member



POLL BATTERED EXECUTIVES

VINAY KATTIYAR Vice-president
MUKHTAR ABBAS NAQVI Vice-president
THAWARCHAND GEHLOT General Secretary
VIJAY GOEL General Secretary
ARJUN MUNDA General Secretary
KIRIT SOMAIYA Secretary



MISSING FROM THE POWER LIST

representative of Scheduled Castes.

Those close to Gadkari defended the team. "He can only choose from the talent available in the party. It was no mean task for him to put together the team as he scouted in states for fresh faces. That is the main reason why the announcement of the team took some time," said a Gadkari aide.

There may be some truth in it as the team Gadkari is far less impressive than the lineup in BJP's heydays with leaders like Atal Bihari Vajpayee, Lal Krishna Advani, Govindacharya, Pramod Mahajan, Yashwant Sinha, Murli Manohar Joshi, Jaswant Singh, Sushma Swaraj and Narendra Modi. Though some of these leaders are on party's Parliamentary Board, the BJP,